The free plastic swap list

Eight swaps, room by room, each backed by Consumer Reports, the American Academy of Pediatrics, UW Medicine or a peer-reviewed study.

Kitchen

Cutting board

Plastic to wood or bamboo

Every cut scrapes tiny pieces off a plastic board, and some end up in the food. Researchers estimated that a polypropylene board can release about 79 million particles a year.

Source: Consumer Reports, 2025; Yadav et al., 2023

Kitchen

Spatulas and spoons

Plastic to wood, bamboo or stainless steel

Plastic tools wear down against hot pans. Consumer Reports also warns about black plastic tools, which can contain flame retardants.

Source: Consumer Reports, 2024 and 2025

Kitchen

Food storage

Plastic to glass or stainless steel

Heat can make plastic containers leak chemicals like BPA and phthalates into food. Pediatricians recommend glass or stainless steel and say to keep plastic out of the dishwasher.

Source: American Academy of Pediatrics, 2018; Consumer Reports, 2025

Kitchen

Reheating

Plastic to ceramic or glass

Three minutes in the microwave released as many as 4 million microplastic particles from each square centimeter of a plastic container. Move food into a ceramic or glass dish first.

Source: Consumer Reports, 2025; American Academy of Pediatrics, 2018; Hussain et al., 2023

Kitchen

Water bottle

Bottled water to a steel or glass bottle

A 2024 study counted about 240,000 plastic particles in a liter of bottled water. Fill a stainless steel or glass bottle with tap or filtered water instead.

Source: Consumer Reports, 2025; Qian et al., 2024

Kitchen

Tea

Plastic tea bags to loose-leaf

In a 2019 study, one plastic tea bag steeped at brewing temperature released about 11.6 billion microplastic particles into a single cup. Loose-leaf tea in a steel strainer skips the bag.

Source: Hernandez et al., 2019

Closet

Clothes and underwear

Polyester and nylon to cotton, linen or wool

Polyester and nylon are plastics, and they shed fibers in the wash. One load of polyester clothes can shed about 496,030 fibers. Cotton, linen and wool are natural fibers.

Source: Napper and Thompson, 2016

Around the house

Dust

Letting it build up to vacuuming often

Dr. Sheela Sathyanarayana, a pediatrician and environmental epidemiologist at UW Medicine, recommends removing dust and vacuuming often to cut exposure at home.

Source: UW Medicine